

smoke, I'd allowed myself to form a habit that had grown completely out of hand and was obviously operating contrary to my best interests, producing no commensurately beneficial results. Suddenly sharply aware of this, I rebelled mentally. I needed only a moment to arrive at a decision. I considered it an excellent idea—and

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an ideal time and place—to rid myself of a habit that was certainly doing me no good.

Having made up my mind, I took the empty cigarette packet that still lay on the nightstand, crumpled it up and tossed it into the wastebasket. Then I undressed, once more put on my pajamas and got back into bed. It was with a sense of relief—even of triumph—that I switched off the light, closed my eyes and listened to the rain beating against the windows of the room. In a few minutes, I drifted off into a sound and contented sleep. I haven't smoked a cigarette—nor have I felt any desire to smoke one—since that night.

Now, I do not intend any of this as an indictment of either cigarettes or smoking. I recount the anecdote solely to show how, in my own case, a habit got out of control to the extent that it controlled me, rather than the other way around.

Practices do become habits—and the force of those habits can, indeed, be mighty. However, human beings have a considerable degree of latitude. They are, after all, endowed with the ability to form their own habits and to break or discard those which they find undesirable.

Nowhere do habit patterns count for as much, and no-where does the force of habit demonstrate its might more emphatically than in the business world. A businessman's habits are among the most important factors that determine whether he will be a success—or a failure.

For instance, it is a helpful habit for a businessman to be optimistic and enthusiastic. It will make his own work better and easier and will also serve